Aquifer Open Study Notes

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1 Corinthians

1 Corinthians 1:1

- An apostle of Christ Jesus was a missionary evangelist sent out with special authority by Christ himself. The term refers to someone who was chosen and given a specific mission to spread the message of Jesus.
- Sosthenes, Paul's co-worker, might be the same person mentioned in Acts 18:17.

1 Corinthians 1:1–3

Paul usually starts his letters by introducing himself. He then offers greetings and wishes for grace and peace. He follows the typical style of ancient Greek letters but adds Christian significance.

1 Corinthians 1:2

The church consists of people called by God to be his holy people. These "holy people" are those who belong to him and are dedicated to him. They are holy because of the work of Christ Jesus. God set them apart as his own people through his Son's saving work and their faith in him.

1 Corinthians 1:3

Grace and peace are traditional Greek and Hebrew greetings. Grace is an unearned blessing from God's kindness. Peace is a feeling of well-being and contentment, based on the Good News and given by the Holy Spirit (see Galatians 5:22). Together, the phrase refers to gifts from God (see Romans 5:1–2).

1 Corinthians 1:4

in Christ Jesus: Paul often uses the phrase in Christ Jesus to describe the saving relationship believers have with Christ (for example, Romans 3:24; Galatians 2:4; Ephesians 3:6).

1 Corinthians 1:4–9

Paul thanks God for the spiritual gifts he sees in the Corinthian Christians. He is confident that God will protect them until the end.

1 Corinthians 1:5

God gave the Corinthian church many spiritual gifts. Two of these were the ability to speak well and the ability to understand spiritual truth. These gifts likely included special messages and insights from the Spirit (see 1 Corinthians 1:7). The church at Corinth took pride in these abilities.

Speech and knowledge appear often in this letter. Paul acknowledges the many spiritual gifts God gave the church in Corinth. Later, he corrects their misunderstandings about these gifts (see 1 Corinthians 1:18–2:5; 3:18–20; 12:1–14:40).

1 Corinthians 1:7

any spiritual gift: See 1 Corinthians 12:8–10 and 28.

1 Corinthians 1:8

Believers are saved from eternal punishment (see Romans 8:1), but they must still answer to God for their actions (see 1 Corinthians 3:12–15; 4:4–5; 2 Corinthians 5:10). Paul urges his readers to live a holy life in order to be blameless when Christ returns (see Philippians 1:6, 10; 1 Thessalonians 3:13; 5:23–24).

1 Corinthians 1:9

- God…is faithful: See 1 Corinthians 10:13; Deuteronomy 7:9; 1 Thessalonians 5:24.
- who has called you: God has chosen them and brought them into partnership with his Son (compare Romans 8:28–39).

1 Corinthians 1:10

- brothers: This term traditionally addresses family members, both male and female.
- I appeal to you: Paul encourages them through the authority of our Lord Jesus Christ, not his own.
- in the name: In Jewish culture, a person's name represented their authority and reputation.
- that there may be no divisions: He wanted them to avoid conflict and be united in thought and purpose, filled with the Spirit of Christ (see Philippians 2:2).

1 Corinthians 1:10–17

The Corinthian believers argued about which leading evangelist (Paul, Apollos, or Peter) was the best. Paul scolded them for their arguments and worldly comparisons. As ministers of Christ and the good news about Jesus, God works through Paul and the others (see 1 Corinthians 3:1–4:7).

1 Corinthians 1:10–15.58

The main part of the letter contains Paul's guidance on specific problems and questions in the Corinthian church.

1 Corinthians 1:11

Chloe was a woman from Corinth, not mentioned in other parts of the Bible.

1 Corinthians 1:12

- The Christians in Corinth had formed groups loyal to different leaders, but the leaders themselves did not seem to be in conflict. Paul, who first brought the Good News to Corinth, received loyalty from some.
- Apollos, now with Paul (see 1 Corinthians 16:12), was an eloquent Jew from Alexandria who became a powerful Christian evangelist and ministered in Corinth (see Acts 18:24–19:1). He attracted followers due to his skillful speaking and ability to interpret Scripture, perhaps in contrast to Paul.
- Peter: Greek Cephas; see also Matthew 16:18; John 1:42. Peter was the main early evangelist to the Jews. He represented a more traditional Jewish perspective and had a talent for speaking to crowds (see Acts 1:15–22; 2:14–40; 3:12–26; 4:8–12; 10:34–43).
- I follow Christ: This might refer to a group who rejected allegiance to any human authority and saw themselves as more holy than others.

1 Corinthians 1:13

Paul asks three rhetorical questions, all expecting the obvious answer, "no." Christians should devote themselves to Christ, not to his messengers.

1 Corinthians 1:14

Crispus and Gaius were two of Paul's first converts in Corinth. Crispus was once a leader of the synagogue in Corinth (see Acts 18:8). Gaius later let Paul use his home (see Romans 16:23). This might mean he was Titius Justus, an earlier convert to Judaism who lived next to the synagogue (see Acts 18:7). His full Roman name would then be Gaius Titius Justus.

1 Corinthians 1:16

The household of Stephanas were the first people to convert in the province of Achaia (southern Greece; see 1 Corinthians 16:15). Household means everyone living in the house, possibly including more than just Stephanas's immediate family.

1 Corinthians 1:17

- The important thing is not baptism, but sharing the good news about Jesus. Baptism shows how people respond to the message.
- not with words of wisdom: This refers to speaking well or appealing to human wisdom.
- lest the cross be emptied of its power: Focusing too much on eloquence and human reasoning can distract from the simple message that Christ died for people's sins so they could be forgiven (1 Corinthians 2:1–5; 15:1–3).

1 Corinthians 1:18

To unbelievers, the idea that God saves the world through a condemned criminal seems foolish because they cannot see the truth (2 Corinthians 4:4). For believers, whom God has enlightened, the message of the cross feels true, and they recognize its power to touch the human heart (see 1 Corinthians 1:23–24; Romans 1:16). Unbelievers, still in their sins, are heading towards destruction and ultimate condemnation. Believers, whose sins are forgiven, are being saved and are on their way to eternal life and glory.

1 Corinthians 1:18–31

Paul contrasts eloquence and human wisdom, which some Corinthians valued, with the seemingly foolish message of the cross, which expresses God's wisdom. The followers of Apollos, in particular (see 1 Corinthians 1:12), were likely drawn to his speaking skills and intellectual approach to ministry (see Acts 18:24–28). In contrast, Paul emphasizes that the true power is in the simple message of the cross of Christ.

1 Corinthians 1:19

This quote from Isaiah 29:14 shows how God views human wisdom.

1 Corinthians 1:20

In God's view, human wisdom based only on the world's knowledge and expectation is foolish. True wisdom comes from the message of the cross and Jesus Christ (see 1 Corinthians 1:24, 30).

1 Corinthians 1:21

Human wisdom alone does not lead people to truly know God. This understanding comes only through the message of the cross. The world sees this message as foolish, but it saves those who believe (see Matthew 11:25).

1 Corinthians 1:22

Jews who did not believe wanted to see miracles to confirm the message (see Matthew 12:38–39; 16:1–4; John 2:18, 23; 4:48). Greeks, famous for their philosophy schools, were interested only in human wisdom, meaning philosophical reasoning.

1 Corinthians 1:22–24

Paul uses the words Greeks and Gentiles interchangeably to refer to non-Jews.

1 Corinthians 1:23

Paul insisted on sharing only the simple message of the cross, despite what unbelieving Jews and Gentiles wanted. Many Jews found the idea of a crucified Messiah contradictory. They believed crucifixion showed God's curse, not His power and blessing (see Galatians 3:13; compare Deuteronomy 21:23).

1 Corinthians 1:25

What the non-believing world sees as foolish and weak (Christ and the message of the cross) is actually wiser and stronger than anything else. It solves the world's biggest problem, which is sin, and defeats all evil forces against people.

1 Corinthians 1:26

Socially and culturally, most Corinthian Christians were ordinary people. Few were among the elite (compare Matthew 11:25). Only a few Christians, such as Erastus, the city treasurer in Corinth (see Romans 16:23), were wealthy or high born (compare James 2:5).

1 Corinthians 1:27–29

God chose humble and overlooked people to show his judgment on human pride (see Romans 3:27; 4:2; 2 Corinthians 4:7–11; 12:8–10; Ephesians 2:9).

1 Corinthians 1:30

because of Him that you are in Christ Jesus: When people unite with Christ Jesus, God makes them righteous, holy, and free (see 1 Corinthians 6:11; Romans 3:21–26; 5:17–21). This work of Christ shows God's wisdom.

1 Corinthians 1:31

"Let him who boasts, boast in the Lord": This quotation paraphrases Jeremiah 9:24 (compare 2 Corinthians 10:17). Salvation comes from God's sovereign power (1 Corinthians 2:5) and his choice to save his people. Therefore, there is no room for human pride (see 1:29).

1 Corinthians 2:1

- When I came to you: see Acts 18:1–17.
- with eloquence or wisdom: Human wisdom and philosophy do not bring people to Christ (see 1 Corinthians 1:17, 21; 2:2). The message of the cross has its own power to change the human heart (see 1:17; Romans 1:16; Galatians 6:14).
- the testimony about God: See study note on 1 Corinthians 2:7.

1 Corinthians 2:1–5

God's control made Paul's preaching successful. Paul did not depend on his intelligence or personality for evangelism. Instead, he relied on the Holy Spirit's power (see also study note on 1 Corinthians 1:18–31).

1 Corinthians 2:3–4

Human weakness does not stop God's work (2 Corinthians 12:7–10). The true power is not in charismatic preaching, presentation skills, or logical arguments (compare 2 Corinthians 10:10). It is in the message itself, focused on Christ and his death for our sins. It is also in the power of the Holy Spirit, who touches the human heart.

1 Corinthians 2:6

- Among the mature: Only those who are spiritually mature will recognize God's wisdom. Many Corinthians could not recognize it (see 1 Corinthians 3:1–3).
- the rulers of this age: The rulers of this world (see also 2:8) are soon forgotten because Christ now rules. His enemies were defeated by his death on the cross (see 15:24–25; Colossians 2:15).

1 Corinthians 2:6–16

Paul highlights God's wisdom as different from the world's wisdom. True wisdom comes from the Spirit and is revealed in the so-called "foolishness" of the good news (see 1 Corinthians 1:20–25).

1 Corinthians 2:7

- mysterious and hidden wisdom: In Paul's writings, "mystery" often means a truth that was once hidden but is now revealed in the good news about Jesus and his saving work (see Romans 11:25–27; 1 Timothy 3:9, 16).
- Before time began: From the start, God wanted to save his chosen people through Jesus (see Romans 16:25–26; Ephesians 1:9–12; 3:3–12; Colossians 1:25–27) and lead them to ultimate glory in the future age (see Romans 5:2; 8:18–21, 29–30; 1 Thessalonians 2:12).

1 Corinthians 2:8

The leaders of this world are likely political leaders, not spiritual ones (see also 1 Corinthians 15:24; compare Acts 3:14–15; 4:10; 5:29–32).

1 Corinthians 2:9

This quotation of Isaiah 64:4 supports Paul's prior point (1 Corinthians 2:8): People without spiritual awareness do not understand God's plan for redemption.

1 Corinthians 2:10–12

- God has revealed it to us: Those who believe in Christ and have received his Spirit (see 1 Corinthians 6:19; 12:13; Galatians 3:2; Ephesians 1:13; Titus 3:5) are different from the rulers of this world (1 Corinthians 2:8). We cannot understand God's deep secrets through worldly wisdom or philosophy. Only God's Spirit can reveal God's thoughts to his people (see 1 John 2:20, 27; compare Matthew 11:25–27). God has kindly given his Spirit to his people so they can know the wonderful things he has freely given them (compare John 16:13–14).

1 Corinthians 2:13

in words taught by the Spirit: Spiritual wisdom differs from human wisdom. The way spiritual wisdom is taught must differ from the way human wisdom is taught. Communicating and learning spiritual truth must happen through the Spirit's dimension and power. It is not just a rational, human exercise.

1 Corinthians 2:14

The natural man: Unbelievers have minds that are closed to the Spirit. They live in the natural world and see life only through physical eyes (see 2 Corinthians 4:4). They cannot understand the importance of the good news about Jesus, as it is mainly a spiritual message.

1 Corinthians 2:15

The spiritual man: Those with the Spirit have a true understanding of divine revelation.

1 Corinthians 2:16

- This quote from Isaiah 40:13 illustrates how divine wisdom goes beyond human understanding (see also Romans 11:34).
- But we have the mind of Christ: Connected to Christ, believers receive the Spirit of Christ, which reveals Christ's thoughts to them.

1 Corinthians 3:1

- The Corinthians did not act like the spiritual people Paul described in 1 Corinthians 2:15. Instead, they behaved like unbelievers drawn to worldly wisdom and values.
- as infants in Christ: Although they converted, their lives and thoughts did not show maturity in Christ or the transformative perspective of his Spirit.

1 Corinthians 3:1–4

Paul criticizes the Christians in Corinth for not growing spiritually.

1 Corinthians 3:1–4.7

After comparing human and spiritual wisdom, Paul addresses the divisions in the Corinthian church (see 1 Corinthians 1:10–12), especially their undue loyalty to him and Apollos.

1 Corinthians 3:2

Because the Corinthian Christians were not spiritually mature, Paul could not discuss the deeper truths of life in Christ, which are like solid food (see 1 Corinthians 2:6–7) meant for mature Christians. Instead, he had to focus on milk, the basic teachings of the good news about Jesus (compare Hebrews 5:12–14; 6:1–3; 1 Peter 2:2).

1 Corinthians 3:3

Their jealousy and arguments (see 1 Corinthians 1:10–12) showed they behaved like unbelievers. They followed their sinful nature, not the Spirit of God (compare 2 Corinthians 12:20; Galatians 5:19–21).

1 Corinthians 3:4

In Greek culture, people often identified with a favorite teacher (see 1 Corinthians 1:12). However, this does not align with the teachings of Christ (3:5–9; compare Matthew 23:8–10).

1 Corinthians 3:5–9

- It is wrong to proudly identify as a follower of a human teacher because God does the real work of redemption. He deserves the honor.
- They are servants: See 2 Corinthians 4:5.

1 Corinthians 3:6

- I planted the seed: See Acts 18:1–11.
- Apollos watered it: See Acts 18:27–19:1.

1 Corinthians 3:10

Paul started the church in Corinth. Now, others are adding to it by teaching the young Christians.

1 Corinthians 3:10–17

Everyone is responsible to God for how they serve Christ.

1 Corinthians 3:11

The church's only foundation is Jesus Christ himself (see Isaiah 28:16; 1 Peter 2:4–8; compare Romans 9:33). However, the Corinthians risked making a human teacher their foundation.

1 Corinthians 3:12–15

Some things people build on Christ's foundation will last. Others will burn in judgment (see Malachi 4:1). On judgment day, the work of each church teacher will be evaluated (see James 3:1; also Romans 14:10–12; 2 Corinthians 5:10). Those with faithful teachings will earn a reward. Others will face great loss, not of salvation but of reward. They will be saved, but barely, like someone rescued through flames (see Amos 4:11; Zechariah 3:2; Jude 1:23).

1 Corinthians 3:16–17

Christians should be careful about what they teach and how they interact with each other. The community of believers is God's temple, where God's Spirit lives (see Ephesians 2:21–22). God's temple is holy (see 1 Corinthians 1:2). There are serious consequences for anyone who harms God's temple through jealousy, arguments, or division (see 3:3–4).

1 Corinthians 3:18–20

Paul contrasts human wisdom with divine wisdom again (see 1 Corinthians 1:18–25). He uses Old Testament quotes to encourage the Corinthians. He urges them to be willing to seem foolish to the world so that they can be truly wise in God's eyes.

1 Corinthians 3:21–23

As God's privileged children, they can now claim everything—the world, life, death, the present, and the future (see Romans 8:38–39). Therefore, claiming a specific human leader is unnecessary.

1 Corinthians 3:23

They may claim everything as their own, but Christ has claimed them for himself (see Romans 14:7–9). In Christ, God ultimately claims them (see 1 Corinthians 6:19–20; 7:23).

1 Corinthians 4:1

- Do not see Paul and Apollos as leaders competing for followers. They are servants of Christ, explaining God's mysteries. They are stewards managing the master's business (as in Luke 12:42). Their lives focus on their master's concerns, not their own.
- mysteries of God: See study note on 1 Corinthians 2:7.

1 Corinthians 4:1–5

Paul highlights his loyalty and sincere intentions as an apostle of Christ. However, only God can judge a person's heart.

1 Corinthians 4:3–4

Paul's greatest wish was to be faithful to God. What people thought of him, including his own opinion, did not matter.

1 Corinthians 4:5

judge nothing: Only the Lord can truly know a person's heart. When he returns, he will judge. Paul took God's judgment of his ministry very seriously (see 2 Corinthians 5:9–10; Philippians 2:16; 1 Thessalonians 2:19–20; compare 2 Corinthians 1:14).

1 Corinthians 4:6–21

Paul criticizes the Corinthian Christians for their arrogance (1 Corinthians 4:6–13) and then advises them like a father (4:14–21).

1 Corinthians 4:7

Pride in a leader comes from not realizing that everything is a gift from God. We should feel humble gratitude instead.

1 Corinthians 4:8–13

Paul points out the difference between himself and the Corinthians. Their attitudes show worldly wisdom, while his shows God's wisdom. The Corinthians were proud and thought they had achieved everything, but they still had much to learn (see Revelation 3:17–18; compare with Philippians 3:12–14). If they had truly achieved everything, they would share in Paul's suffering (1 Corinthians 4:11–13). Unlike the Corinthians, who were proud of their achievements and the respect they received, the apostles faced scorn and contempt.

1 Corinthians 4:9

God has displayed us apostles: Like prisoners condemned to die by facing wild animals in the amphithe-

ater, the apostles were a spectacle. Paul gladly accepted suffering because God used it to bless others (see 2 Corinthians 1:4–7; 4:7–12; Philippians 2:17; Colossians 1:24).

1 Corinthians 4:11–13

Paul reminds the Corinthians of the hardships he endured for Christ (see 2 Corinthians 6:4–5; 11:23–28).

1 Corinthians 4:12

- We work hard with our own hands: To avoid accusations of taking money, Paul chose to support himself (1 Corinthians 9:3–18; Acts 18:3; 20:33–35).
- When we are vilified, we bless: Paul's response followed the teachings of Jesus (Matthew 5:44–45; compare Romans 12:14, 17–21).

1 Corinthians 4:14–16

As their spiritual father who first shared the good news about Jesus, Paul shows his true concern for their well-being (see 1 Thessalonians 2:11–12). As his beloved children, they should listen to him and follow his example and teachings (see 1 Corinthians 11:1; Galatians 4:12; Philippians 3:17; 4:9; 1 Thessalonians 1:6; 2 Thessalonians 3:7–9).

1 Corinthians 4:14–21

Paul ends this part about divisions in the church with kind, fatherly advice and a warning (1 Corinthians 1:10–4:21).

1 Corinthians 4:17

Timothy, Paul's spiritual child and close associate, was with Paul when he first preached the good news about Jesus in Corinth (see 2 Corinthians 1:19). Paul sent him to clearly explain what it means to follow Christ Jesus.

1 Corinthians 4:18–20

Some might have thought Paul was afraid to visit because he sent Timothy. However, Paul was very busy with his work in Ephesus at that time (Acts 19:8–20; see study note on Acts 19:10). He planned to visit soon (see 1 Corinthians 16:5–9; Acts 19:21–22; 20:1–3; compare 2 Corinthians 1:15–2:4) and would face those who opposed him. He would show they were just talkers. His actions and words would prove God's power (see also 1 Corinthians 2:4).

1 Corinthians 5:1

sexual immorality: A man was having sexual relations with his stepmother. Even pagans did not engage in such behavior. It violated both the law of Moses (see Leviticus 18:7–8) and Roman law (Gaius, Institutes 1.63).

1 Corinthians 5:1–8

Paul addresses sexual immorality in the church and tells the Christians to remove an unashamed wrongdoer from fellowship.

1 Corinthians 5:2

- The Corinthian Christians were proud (see 1 Corinthians 4:8, 10, 18; 5:6), but they should have felt sorrow and shame for the sin among them.
- have removed from your fellowship the man: This instruction suggests that the man ignored their requests, or that such obvious sin needed immediate discipline (compare Matthew 18:15–18).

1 Corinthians 5:3

in spirit: Paul shared a spiritual connection with them. He had authority from God through the Spirit, which worked well among them.

1 Corinthians 5:5

- The instruction to remove this man is not directly in the Greek text but is suggested by 1 Corinthians 5:2, 13.
- hand this man over to Satan: Compare with 1 Timothy 1:20. Those outside God's church fall under Satan's power and control (see Ephesians 2:2; 1 John 5:19).
- for the destruction of the flesh: The flesh could mean his evil desires or his physical life (for example, so that he will die).
- so that his spirit may be saved: He might repent and avoid condemnation (compare with 2 Corinthians 2:5–8).
- on the Day of the Lord: This includes the final judgment.

1 Corinthians 5:6–7

- Yeast often symbolized sin (see Matthew 16:6, 12; Mark 8:15; Luke 12:1; Galatians 5:9). Jews ceremonially removed yeast from their homes before the annual Passover meal (Exodus 12:19; 13:7).
- Get rid of the old leaven: If left unchecked, sin could spread throughout the church, just as yeast spreads through dough.

1 Corinthians 5:7–8

Paul compares the Jewish Passover celebration to Christ's sacrifice. During Passover, people sacrificed a lamb and ate unleavened bread (see Exodus 12:1–27;

13:3–7). Christ's sacrifice, which happened at Passover (Matthew 26:2; compare John 1:29; 1 Peter 1:19), removes sin for believers.

1 Corinthians 5:9

- I wrote you in my letter refers to an earlier letter that is now lost.
- Sexual sin includes any form of illegal sexual activity (see also 1 Corinthians 6:9).

1 Corinthians 5:9–13

The church should guide and correct anyone known to be living in sin.

1 Corinthians 5:10

Paul usually advised believers to stay connected with sinful non-believers (for example, 1 Corinthians 10:27).

1 Corinthians 5:11

Separating from a believer living in sin was intended to uphold the Christian community's high moral standards. This social pressure might also encourage a brother or sister to repent (see 2 Thessalonians 3:6, 14).

1 Corinthians 5:12–13

Christians should not judge or discipline the sins of non-believers, but they should address the sins of fellow believers.

1 Corinthians 6:1–11

When serious disagreements occur between two Christians, they should resolve them with the help of other believers, not in a secular court.

1 Corinthians 6:2–3

One day, believers will help judge the world. Even angels will assist alongside the Son of Man, who is the Judge of all people (see Daniel 7:13, 22, 27; Matthew 19:28; John 5:27; Acts 17:31; Revelation 3:21; 20:4). Because of this responsibility, Christians should resolve their disagreements over small matters.

1 Corinthians 6:4–6

I say this to your shame: It is a problem for Christians to settle disputes in non-religious courts, as if no one in the church can help resolve them.

1 Corinthians 6:7

- The very fact that you have lawsuits among you means that you are thoroughly defeated already: Suing a fellow believer shows self-interest instead of caring for others or honoring God.
- Why not rather be wronged?: Christians should follow Christ's example of self-sacrifice (see Matthew 5:38–42).

1 Corinthians 6:8

Some of the Corinthian believers were not following Christ's example of sacrificial love. They were cheating even their fellow believers. Their actions and attitudes were wrong.

1 Corinthians 6:9

- Do not be deceived: Sin is misleading, and believers should not take it lightly or think it is acceptable (Jeremiah 17:9).
- Continuing to engage in sexual sin without repentance shows a heart not renewed by the Holy Spirit. Sexual sins include adultery (see Exodus 20:14; Matthew 5:27–28) and practicing homosexuality (compare Leviticus 18:22; 20:13; Romans 1:26–27; 1 Timothy 1:10).

1 Corinthians 6:9–11

People who choose to sin will not be part of the kingdom of God. Christians should live in a way that shows their faith.

1 Corinthians 6:10

nor ... will inherit the kingdom of God: Repeating this point (also 6:9) highlights the serious consequences of living in sin. For similar warnings, see Galatians 5:19–21; Ephesians 5:5; compare Colossians 3:5–6.

1 Corinthians 6:11

- After the strong warning in Leviticus 6:9–10, Paul reassures his readers of their true conversion.
- But you were washed: (see Acts 22:16) Cleanliness symbolizes the righteousness that comes from forgiveness (see Titus 3:5). God himself made them holy (see 1 Corinthians 1:2).
- They became right with God through their connection with the Lord Jesus Christ and the transformative work of the Spirit of our God. God forgave them. He views them as righteous (see Romans 1:17; 3:21–26), and their lives have truly improved (see Titus 3:5–7).

1 Corinthians 6:12

Some Christians believed they could do anything, including being sexually immoral. Paul disagrees, saying

not everything is beneficial. True Christians should live disciplined lives (see 10:23; Galatians 5:13).

1 Corinthians 6:12–20

Paul provides several reasons why Christians should avoid sexual immorality.

1 Corinthians 6:13–14

"Food for the stomach and the stomach for food": Some Corinthian Christians used this idea to justify their sexual immorality. They claimed, "The body was made for sex, and sex for the body." This analogy is false because our bodies were made for the Lord, and sexual immorality does not honor him. Given his care for our bodies and the future resurrection, we must use our bodies for holy purposes in God's service.

1 Corinthians 6:15–17

Being a Christian means being spiritually connected to Christ in both life and death (see Romans 6:3–11). Because of this, believers' bodies are parts of Christ (see 1 Corinthians 12:12–28; Romans 12:4–5). This spiritual connection (see John 14:20; 17:21–23) means they should not misuse their bodies by joining with a prostitute.

1 Corinthians 6:18–20

- For Christians, the body is a temple of the Holy Spirit (see study note on 1 Corinthians 3:16–17; compare 2 Corinthians 6:16). Sexual sin violates this sacred space and the divine presence.
- You are not your own: Christians cannot claim their bodies as their own because they have been bought with a high price, the blood of Christ (compare 1 Corinthians 7:23; Revelation 5:9). Christ has claimed every part of their lives for God's glory (see Romans 14:7–9; 2 Corinthians 5:14–15).

1 Corinthians 7:1

It is good to abstain from sexual relations: Both Paul and Jesus encouraged living a celibate life for God (see Matthew 19:10–12). Paul's emphasis on celibacy may have been shaped by his expectation that the end of the age was near (see 1 Corinthians 7:29–31).

1 Corinthians 7:1–40

Paul often says that true Christians, as servants of Christ, belong completely to Christ for his service. Because of this, he suggests Christians stay single. However, he admits that getting married is not a sin.

1 Corinthians 7:1–16.4

Paul now answers the questions the Corinthians asked him in a letter, starting with the topic of marriage (see 1 Corinthians 7:25; 8:1; 12:1; 16:1).

1 Corinthians 7:2

Due to widespread sexual immorality, Paul advises most Christians to marry (1 Corinthians 7:9). He balances the ideal of celibacy with an understanding of physical needs.

1 Corinthians 7:3–4

To avoid the temptation of sexual immorality, married Christians should consider their spouse's sexual needs. Both partners have the right to sexual intimacy in marriage, and they should not withhold it. In marriage, each person gives their spouse authority over their body, but this authority should never be abused.

1 Corinthians 7:6–7

Paul prefers being single, but he acknowledges that both marriage and being single are gifts from God to different people.

1 Corinthians 7:8–9

Paul advises that staying unmarried is better because it allows more opportunities to serve Christ without distraction (1 Corinthians 7:32–35). However, even with its distractions, an honorable marriage is much better than living with unsatisfied sexual desire.

1 Corinthians 7:10–11

- Paul advises Christian couples considering divorce.
- not I, but the Lord: This does not mean Paul's other instructions (see 1 Corinthians 7:12, 25, 40) have less authority. It means this advice is based on known teachings of Jesus (see Matthew 5:32; 19:9; Mark 10:11–12; Luke 16:18).
- But if she does: Paul recognizes that some couples struggle to live together, but even then, they must honor their marriage vows and remain faithful to their spouse alone (see 1 Corinthians 7:27; Romans 7:2).

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1 Corinthians 7:12–13

- Paul now addresses Christians married to non-believers.
- I, not the Lord: Paul knew of no specific teaching from Jesus for this situation, but his advice is clear.

Believers should remain faithful and honor their marriage commitment.

1 Corinthians 7:14

By staying committed to the marriage, the Christian makes the unbelieving spouse holy. This holiness also benefits the children, who gain from having a Christian parent (see Malachi 2:15).

1 Corinthians 7:15

If the unbeliever ends the marriage, the believing husband or wife can let them go. God wants his people to live in peace, not in the unbearable conflict of a mixed marriage that the non-Christian spouse no longer wants.

1 Corinthians 7:16

There is always hope that the believing spouse will lead the unbelieving partner to faith in Christ. However, the Greek text is unclear and might also mean there is no guarantee the believing partner will ever convince the unbelieving spouse.

1 Corinthians 7:17

Generally, Christians should stay in the social situation they were in when they first became believers (see 1 Corintihans 7:20, 24).

1 Corinthians 7:17–24

Paul says Christians should accept the life God has given them.

1 Corinthians 7:18–19

Circumcision shows the principle mentioned earlier (1 Corinthians 7:17). All Jewish males were circumcised. Some tried to reverse it to fit into Gentile society (see 1 Maccabees 1:14–15; Josephus, Antiquities 12.5.1), but Paul advises against this. Circumcision is not very important compared to following God's commandments, like loving God and others (see also Romans 2:28–29; 4:9–12; Galatians 5:2–6; 6:12–15; Philippians 3:2–3).

1 Corinthians 7:21–23

- Slavery shows the general idea mentioned in 1 Corinthians 7:17, 20, 24. Slavery was common in the Greco-Roman world, and many Christian converts were slaves serving wealthy families. According to Paul, like circumcision, being a slave is not very important for a Christian. Even as a slave, a Christian is spiritually free from sin, death, and the law (see Romans 6:14; 7:4–6; 8:2). As a free person, the believer is still a servant of Christ (see Ephesians 6:5–6; 1 Peter 2:16).
- As someone bought at a high price, the free Christian should not be controlled by the world (see 1 Cor 6:20).

1 Corinthians 7:25–35

Paul provides three reasons why it is often better for single people to stay unmarried. First, single people face fewer daily problems than married people. Second, since the end is near, Christians should not let marriage and worldly matters be their main focus. Their main focus should be Christ and eternity. Third, marriage involves earthly responsibilities and divided interests, so those who stay single can dedicate their lives more fully to serving Christ.

1 Corinthians 7:36–38

Paul suggests choosing a celibate life over marriage. However, he permits marriage if sexual desires become too tempting. Those who can control their desires well should consider celibacy.

1 Corinthians 7:39

A widow may marry another man, but only if he loves the Lord. Paul strongly advised Christians not to marry non-believers (see 2 Corinthians 6:14–16).

1 Corinthians 8:1

"We all have knowledge" was a saying among the Corinthian Christians. The knowledge referred to religious understanding. Some Christians believed their superior knowledge made them ignore others' opinions.

1 Corinthians 8:1–11.1

Paul addresses the Corinthians' question about eating food offered to idols. In the Greco-Roman world, temples and shrines dedicated to pagan gods were common. Worshipers often offered animal sacrifices, and pagan priests sold the extra meat in the market. Christians wondered if they could eat this meat.

Was meat from a sacrifice to a pagan god impure? Paul does not mention the Jewish Christian leaders' prohibition in Acts 15:20, 29. Instead, he stresses that actions should be guided by love and consideration for others. After introducing the topic (1 Corinthians 8:1–13), he shares examples of giving up one's rights for others' sake (9:1–27) and offers advice on three specific situations believers faced.

1 Corinthians 8:2–3

God acknowledges those who truly love Him, not just those who know all the answers (see 1 Corinthians 13:12; Galatians 4:9).

1 Corinthians 8:4–6

In reality, the idols to which such meat is sacrificed are not gods, because there is only one God (Deuteronomy 6:4; see also Deuteronomy 4:35, 39; 10:19–20). He is the Creator of everything, including the meat being sacrificed for the idols. The only ultimate reality is God, the Father, and the one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom all things were created (see also John 1:3; Colossians 1:16; Hebrews 1:2).

1 Corinthians 8:7

Many Corinthian believers grew up in a pagan world and saw eating such meat as worshiping the god it was sacrificed to. For these Christians, eating meat offered to an idol would go against their weak consciences (see 8:10–12; 10:28–29; Romans 14:13–23).

1 Corinthians 8:8

The Corinthians' connection with God did not depend on whether they ate certain foods or not, regardless of the food's source (compare Romans 14:17).

1 Corinthians 8:9–10

Believers should ensure their actions, like eating sacrificial meat, do not cause others to struggle (compare Romans 14:13, 20–21; Galatians 5:13).

1 Corinthians 8:11

- Believers who insist on eating food offered to idols (because they believe their knowledge allows them to eat it) could harm less mature Christians. These less mature Christians may see eating this meat as worshipping pagan gods.
- for whom Christ died: Compare Romans 14:15.

1 Corinthians 8:12

Causing immature believers to sin by violating their conscience is like sinning against Christ, who has claimed them for himself (compare Matthew 25:40, 45).

1 Corinthians 8:13

Personal rights must come second to the greater responsibility of not causing another believer to struggle.

1 Corinthians 9:1–2

- These four rhetorical questions expect a positive answer. The first question, following his discussion in 8:1–13, asserts Paul's freedom from Jewish ritual obligations. However, he later emphasizes (see 9:19–23) that he willingly follows Jewish practices to win them to Christ. The other three questions assert Paul's apostolic authority, which some in Corinth questioned.
- For you are the seal: For skeptics, Paul's apostolic calling was confirmed by his encounter with Jesus on the road to Damascus (see 15:8; Acts 9:3–6, 17). Also, the Corinthians, who came to faith through Paul's evangelism (see Acts 18:1–11), were proof of his status as an apostle.

1 Corinthians 9:1–27

Continuing the argument from 8:1, Paul shares personal examples of giving up his rights to help others (see study note on 1 Corinthians 8:1–11:1).

1 Corinthians 9:3

- This is my defense: This is a legal term for the argument made in response to accusations.
- those who scrutinize me: See 2 Corinthians 11–12 for another response to their challenge.

1 Corinthians 9:4

As an apostle, Paul had the right to expect food and housing from those he served (compare 9:14; Luke 10:7–8). However, to avoid any criticism, he chose not to use this right (see 9:6, 12, 14–15, 18; 2 Corinthians 11:7–9; 12:13–14).

1 Corinthians 9:5

- the Lord's brothers: See Mark 6:3 for their names.
- Cephas: Mark 1:30 mentions that Peter (also called Cephas) was married.

1 Corinthians 9:7–10

These examples support Paul's point that he and other Christian workers had the right to receive support from those they served.

1 Corinthians 9:12

Paul believed he deserved support from the Corinthians more than other Christian workers because he first shared the good news about Jesus with them. However, he chose not to use this right to avoid criticism (see 9:6, 14–15, 18; compare Acts 18:3; 2 Cor 11:7–9; 12:13–14).

1 Corinthians 9:13

Paul might be referring to Levites and priests at God's temple in Jerusalem (see Deuteronomy 18:1–4; compare Leviticus 6:16–17, 26; Numbers 18:8–32), but pagan priests in temples around Corinth likely did the same.

1 Corinthians 9:14

the Lord has prescribed: Refer to Matthew 10:10 and Luke 10:7. Also see Galatians 6:6 and 1 Timothy 5:17–18.

1 Corinthians 9:15

Paul had never insisted on his rights, and he was not trying to do so now. Instead, he showed the importance of giving up one's rights to help others (compare 8:13).

1 Corinthians 9:16

I am obligated: See Acts 22:14–15; 26:16–18.

1 Corinthians 9:18

Paul felt satisfied preaching the good news about Jesus without asking for payment. This sets an example for how Christians must be willing to give up their rights to help others (see 8:13).

1 Corinthians 9:19–23

Paul puts himself in the humble position of a servant in the household. He shows how much he was willing to change his lifestyle and behavior to match the people he preached to, in order to bring them to Christ.

1 Corinthians 9:24–27

- To show how seriously the Corinthians must take their salvation, Paul refers to the Isthmian games, a well-known athletic event held in Corinth every two years.
- Everyone who competes in the games trains with strict discipline: Athletes must have strict self-discipline to compete for a prize. In Paul's time, athletes trained rigorously for months before competing. Similarly, strict self-discipline (see Galatians 5:22–23) is needed to achieve the eternal prize of salvation. Christians must follow the daily discipline of obeying Christ.
- for a crown that is perishable: Athletic prizes were often wreaths made of laurel leaves (see 2 Timothy 4:8; James 1:12; 1 Peter 5:4; Revelation 2:10).

1 Corinthians 9:26

I do not fight like I am beating the air: Christians need to truly follow Christ instead of just acting like they do.

1 Corinthians 9:27

I myself will not be disqualified: Those disqualified from a sporting event cannot win the prize. To avoid losing the eternal prize, Paul disciplined himself strictly, like an athlete, to stay close to Christ and avoid sin (see 9:25; Hebrews 12:1).

1 Corinthians 10:1–11

The Israelites were God's people and experienced his salvation and provision (see Exodus 13:21–22; 14:21–29). However, they still faced his judgment because they disobeyed.

1 Corinthians 10:1–22

After sharing a personal example about giving up one's rights for others (chapter 9), Paul addresses the issue of eating meat offered to idols (8:1–13). He warns believers about God's anger towards those who sin, especially those involved in idol worship.

1 Corinthians 10:2

They were all baptized: Paul begins a comparison. He connects the Israelites in the time of the exodus with the Corinthians who were baptized.

1 Corinthians 10:3–4

- the same spiritual food: God provided food and water supernaturally in the wilderness for the Israelites (see Exodus 16:4–35; 17:1–7; Numbers 20:2–17). The Corinthians faced a similar situation.
- the spiritual rock that accompanied them: refers to the rock Moses struck to get water (Exodus 17:1–7; Numbers 20:2–17). Early Jewish tradition believed both miracles involved the same traveling rock.
- that rock was Christ: Paul explains Israel's experience as a parallel to God's provision in the wilderness and the Lord's Supper (1 Corinthians 10:14–18; compare John 4:14; 7:37–39; Revelation 22:17). Both Israelites and Christians share in Christ's spiritual provisions. Just as the Israelites were judged for their sins, Christians will also be judged if they sin (1 Corinthians 10:5–22).

1 Corinthians 10:6

evil things: see Numbers 11:4–6, 34.

1 Corinthians 10:7

Feasting and drinking involve celebrations for pagan gods. Pagan revelry means wild parties with drinking and sexual activities.

1 Corinthians 10:8

Refer to Numbers 25:1–9.

1 Corinthians 10:9

- We should not test Christ: See Deuteronomy 6:16; Psalm 78:18–20; Matthew 4:7.
- Christ: Some manuscripts say the Lord, likely a scribe's effort to match the Old Testament context.

1 Corinthians 10:10

Refer to Numbers 16:13–14, 41–49.

1 Corinthians 10:12–13

Paul warns the Corinthians not to fall into sin (compare Romans 11:20–22). He reminds them that God is faithful (see 1 Corinthians 1:9; compare Deuteronomy 7:9; 1 Peter 4:19). God will not let them face temptation (compare James 1:2–4) beyond what they can handle. He will always provide a way out.

1 Corinthians 10:14–22

Paul warns his readers against anything that might be seen as idolatry (see 1 John 5:21), including eating food to honor a pagan god.

1 Corinthians 10:16–18

Paul explains the spiritual meaning of sacred meals. In the Lord's Supper, believers share in the blood and body of Christ (see also 11:17–34; Matthew 26:26–28; Mark 14:22–24; Luke 22:19–20). Sharing one loaf unites believers as one body in Christ, similar to how pagans' religious meals connect them with the gods they worship (see 1 Corinthians 10:19–21).

1 Corinthians 10:19–20

Idols lack reality or life (see 8:4–6), and sacrifices to them achieve nothing. When pagans sacrifice to idols, they unknowingly sacrifice to demons (see Deuteronomy 32:16–17; Psalm 106:37; Revelation 9:20). By participating in these religious meals, people unite with demons.

1 Corinthians 10:21

Believers should avoid joining in religious meals in a pagan temple (see 8:10). Those united with the Lord (Christ) cannot also unite with demons (see 2 Corinthians 6:14–16).

1 Corinthians 10:22

If you ignore Paul's advice on this matter, you may provoke the Lord's jealousy and judgment, as Israel did (see 10:6–11; Exodus 20:5; Deuteronomy 32:21).

1 Corinthians 10:23–24

- "Everything is permissible": Paul is likely quoting a common saying among the Corinthians and explaining it.
- Paul clarifies a Christian's freedom by stressing the importance of doing what benefits others (see 6:12; 10:32–33; Romans 14:13–15, 19–21; 15:1–2; compare Philippians 2:3–4).

1 Corinthians 10:23–11.1

Paul concludes the discussion started in 8:1 with guidance on when Christians may eat meat offered to an idol and when they should not (see study note on 1 Corinthians 8:1–11:1). His guidance emphasizes the principle of giving up one's rights out of love (see also 8:13–9:23).

1 Corinthians 10:27–29

When Christians are invited to a meal with a nonbeliever, they can eat what is served unless told the meat was offered to an idol. In that case, Christians should not eat it to respect the other person's beliefs. The person might think eating the meat honors the idol (see 8:7, 9–10; compare Romans 14:13–15, 20–23).

1 Corinthians 10:29–30

These two questions are hard to understand in relation to 10:28–29a. Some translations place 10:28–29a in parentheses, suggesting these questions reflect Paul's beliefs, continuing from 10:27.

1 Corinthians 10:31–33

Paul ends his discussion by summarizing two principles to guide Christian behavior:

1. Believers should do everything to honor God (see Colossians 3:17; 1 Peter 4:11).
2. Believers should avoid offending others and should not harm another person's Christian faith (compare 1 Corinthians 8:9, 13; 1 John 2:10). Christians should prioritize what is best for others over personal privilege (compare Romans 14:13–15, 19–21; 15:1–2). These two principles are central to Paul's advice on practical Christian living in this letter.

1 Corinthians 11:1

imitate me: Compare 4:16; Philippians 3:17.

1 Corinthians 11:2

the traditions, just as I passed them on to you: This phrase usually means an important tradition of Christian teaching shared by word of mouth (see also 11:23; 15:1–3; 2 Thessalonians 2:15).

1 Corinthians 11:3

the head of every man is Christ, and the head of the woman is man, and the head of Christ is God: The word head serves as a metaphor for either source or authority. The immediate context and Paul's overall teaching suggest that head means authority in this context (see Genesis 3:16; Ephesians 5:21–23; Colossians 3:18; 1 Peter 3:1).

1 Corinthians 11:3–16

Paul discusses a woman's use of a head covering. He argues that women who pray or prophesy in public should wear a veil. This is to dress modestly and appropriately during worship (compare 1 Timothy 2:9; 1 Peter 3:3). Some in Corinth were not wearing head coverings, citing freedom in Christ. Paul supports the custom based on social traditions, the Genesis creation story, and the presence of angels.

1 Corinthians 11:4–6

- In this passage, head is used both literally and figuratively. A man who covers his physical head while praying dishonors his spiritual head, Christ. A woman who prays or prophesies without covering her physical head dishonors her spiritual head, her husband.
- The spiritual gift of prophesying is the God-given ability to speak a specific message from God, not just to predict the future (see 12:10; 14:1–5; 1 Thessalonians 5:20).
- every woman who prays or prophesies: Women were allowed to pray and prophesy publicly in the church (see Acts 21:9).

1 Corinthians 11:7

he is the image and glory of God: See Genesis 1:26–27.

1 Corinthians 11:10

- because of the angels: Angels are guardians of the world, ensuring everything follows God's plan (see Genesis 19:1–21; 22:11–12; Exodus 23:20; Numbers 22:22–23; Psalms 34:7; 91:11; 103:20–21; Hebrews 1:7, 14). Believers should act appropriately in front of others and God's observing angels (compare 1 Timothy 5:21).
- ought to have a sign of authority on her head: should wear a covering on her head to show she is under authority.

1 Corinthians 11:11–12

But everything comes from God (compare 8:6): Both men and women must ultimately submit to God, who is the head of all.

1 Corinthians 11:13

Judge for yourselves...Is it proper?: This rhetorical question expects the answer "no."

1 Corinthians 11:14

Doesn't nature itself teach you?: In Paul's culture, men did not wear long hair.

1 Corinthians 11:15

- Paul argues that social rules about hair length show basic differences between men and women.
- For long hair is given to her as a covering: Paul suggests that women's long hair, which covers their heads, indicates that God wants women to have some form of "covering."

1 Corinthians 11:16

- If anyone is inclined to dispute this: Some members of the diverse Corinthian church disagreed with Paul.
- Paul's final point is that wearing a head covering was a long-standing church custom. Most modern interpreters believe this custom was based on culture.

1 Corinthians 11:17

your gatherings: Early Christians met in someone's home at least once a week, usually on the Lord's Day (see 16:2).

1 Corinthians 11:17–34

Paul discusses issues with how the Corinthians interact with each other and with the Lord during the Lord's Supper.

1 Corinthians 11:18

The divisions might refer to those mentioned in 1:10–12 (compare Titus 3:10), or more likely, they result from social discrimination during shared meals (see 1 Corinthians 11:21–22, 33; Acts 6:1).

1 Corinthians 11:19

This ironic expression criticizes the Corinthian Christians for claiming superiority based on their differences. Alternatively, Paul might suggest that while their divisiveness is wrong, it will reveal who among them is truly faithful.

1 Corinthians 11:20–22

Some people cared more about eating their own dinner than about the Lord's Supper.

1 Corinthians 11:23

- For I received from the Lord what I also passed on to you: This is one of the few clear references in Paul's letters to traditions passed down from Christ (see also 7:10; 9:14; compare 1 Thessalonians 4:15–17).
- On the night he was betrayed: See Mark 14:43–46.

1 Corinthians 11:24

- Jews and early Christians traditionally thanked God for their food before eating (see study note on Mark 14:22–25).
- This is My body: Compare John 6:32–35, 48–58.

1 Corinthians 11:25

- After supper may suggest that the main meal separated the breaking of the bread from the drinking of the cup (see Luke 22:20).
- The new covenant is God's promise to forgive sins because of Jesus' sacrificial death (compare Jeremiah 31:31–34; 32:40; Luke 22:20; Hebrews 7:22; 8:8–10; 9:15; 10:12–18; 12:24; 13:20). The blood of a sacrifice confirmed an agreement or covenant (see Exodus 24:8; Zechariah 9:11; Hebrews 9:12; 13:20; compare Romans 3:25; 5:9).

1 Corinthians 11:26

When Christians take the Lord's Supper, they share the importance of the Lord's death with others until he returns (see 1:7–8; compare 1 Thessalonian 1:9–10; 3:12; 4:13–18; 5:23).

1 Corinthians 11:27

Taking the Lord's Supper without understanding its importance or with unconfessed sin is unworthy (see 11:28–31). It is like sinning against the body and blood of the Lord; it treats his sacrificial death as unimportant (compare Hebrews 10:29).

1 Corinthians 11:28

Before taking the Lord's Supper, Christians should confess their sins and think about what the bread and cup mean (11:26).

1 Corinthians 11:29–30

- In light of 11:27, the body of Christ likely refers to the death of Christ, not the church, though some interpret it that way.
- Those who eat the bread or drink the cup in an unworthy manner bring God's judgment upon themselves. This judgment may result in infirmities, sickness, or even death (see Acts 5:5, 10).

1 Corinthians 11:31

Judging yourself, which means admitting your sins and repenting, prevents God's judgment.

1 Corinthians 11:32

When God judges and disciplines his people (see Deuteronomy 8:5; Hebrews 12:5–11), it is for their ultimate benefit. This ensures they are not condemned with the world (see Ephesians 2:1–3).

1 Corinthians 11:34

when I come: Paul was planning to visit soon (4:19; 16:5–7).

1 Corinthians 12:1–3

Paul introduces the topic and highlights how the Holy Spirit actively works in believers.

1 Corinthians 12:1–14.40

The church in Corinth focused too much on the gift of speaking in tongues (see 14:1–25, 27; compare the lists in 12:8–10, 28, where Paul lists tongues last). Paul offers advice to correct their understanding of the value and use of spiritual gifts.

1 Corinthians 12:2

pagans: Non-Jewish people who do not follow a major religion.

1 Corinthians 12:3

Paul provides two ways to recognize the Spirit's presence in worship:

1. Those who curse Jesus show they reject him and his message, so they cannot speak by the Spirit of God.
2. Believers show the Holy Spirit's presence in their lives by sincerely confessing that Jesus is Lord. This

may be the earliest Christian creed (see Romans 10:9, 13; 2 Corinthians 4:5; Philippians 2:11; 1 John 4:2–3).

1 Corinthians 12:4–11

Believers are united in the Lord and his Spirit, but God gives different spiritual gifts to each person. These gifts help them serve the same Lord in various ways (see also 7:7; 12:7–11, 28–31; Romans 12:6–8; Ephesians 4:11).

1 Corinthians 12:6

All the work believers do for God is actually God working through them (see 15:10; 2 Corinthians 4:7; Galatians 2:8; Philippians 2:13; compare Galatians 2:20).

1 Corinthians 12:7

Spiritual gifts are not for the benefit of the person who receives them. They are meant to help others (see 1 Peter 4:10–11).

1 Corinthians 12:8

- God's Spirit provides supernatural wisdom or knowledge to some believers.
- to another the message of knowledge: see 1:5; 8:1; 13:2, 8.

1 Corinthians 12:8–10

This list of nine spiritual gifts is an example, not a complete list (see also 12:28–30; Romans 12:6–8; Ephesians 4:11).

1 Corinthians 12:9

The spiritual gift of great faith is different from the faith needed for salvation. It is an exceptional ability to trust God for specific needs (see 13:2; Matthew 17:19–20; compare Acts 6:5; 11:24).

1 Corinthians 12:10

- Prophesying means delivering a special message from God, not just predicting the future (see 11:4–5; 13:2, 8; 14:1–25, 29–33; 1 Thessalonians 5:20; compare Acts 13:1–2; 21:4, 10–11).
- The gift to discern if a message is from God's Spirit or another spirit is essential for any Christian community open to God's word (see 1 Corinthians 14:29; 1 Thessalonians 5:19–21; compare Acts 16:16–18; 1 John 4:1–3).
- For Paul, speaking in unknown languages means using a spiritual language that needs the gift of interpretation to be understood. By ranking this gift lower (both here and in 1 Corinthians 12:28), Paul indicates that the gift of tongues is less important, as the Corinthian church had become overly fascinated with it (compare 13:1, 8; 14:1–25, 27).
- The ability to interpret is not about translating with natural skill, but about spiritually understanding the Spirit's message through the gift of tongues (see 14:5, 13, 26–28).

1 Corinthians 12:11

the same Spirit, who apportions them to each one as He determines: See 12:4, 6, 18, 28. Paul affirms both God's choice in giving spiritual gifts and the human duty to "earnestly desire the most helpful gifts" (12:31).

1 Corinthians 12:12–31

The church is like a body (see 12:27) made up of many different parts. Each part has its own role, as determined by God (see 12:11, 18, 28; Romans 12:4–5).

1 Corinthians 12:13

- Ethnic and social differences do not matter in the church (see Galatians 3:28; Colossians 3:11).
- For in one Spirit we were all baptized into one body: Water baptism represents a spiritual baptism. In this, the Holy Spirit unites the believer with Christ and the church.

1 Corinthians 12:14–21

These verses shift from the image of a physical body to the image of the church as a spiritual body. Every part of the body is important and essential for it to work well. Believers should not brag about their spiritual roles or think less of them compared to others. God, who created the body, has placed each part exactly where he wants it (12:18).

1 Corinthians 12:22–26

The weaker and less noticeable body parts are very important. They need special care and respect for the whole body to work well.

1 Corinthians 12:25–26

The church is a united group, so members must live in harmony and care for one another.

1 Corinthians 12:28

- Apostles are special messengers of Christ in the world (see also Ephesians 4:11).
- Prophets deliver messages from God (see 1 Corinthians 12:10 and related study note; Ephesians 4:11; compare Acts 13:1–2).

- Teachers educate others about the faith (Romans 12:7; Ephesians 4:11; compare Acts 13:1).
- various tongues: See study note on 1 Corinthians 12:10.

1 Corinthians 12:28–31

Paul describes various roles assigned to individuals in the church (see also the list in 12:8–10; compare Romans 12:6–8; Ephesians 4:11).

1 Corinthians 12:29–30

These rhetorical questions all expect the answer, "Of course not!" Paul gently corrects those who feel jealous of others. Believers should gratefully accept the gifts God has given them. They should not envy other gifts or consider any gifts more important than others (but see 12:31).

1 Corinthians 12:31

- Believers should eagerly seek the most helpful gifts, those with the greatest potential to strengthen the church (see 14:12). They should remember that God distributes gifts as he chooses (12:11, 18, 28). Paul encourages the Corinthians to look beyond their desire for the gift of tongues (compare 14:1–25, 27; see 12:10) because it has the least potential to strengthen the church.
- And now I will show you the most excellent way: This statement leads to Paul's description of love in 13:1–13. Love is the best way of life.

1 Corinthians 13:1

tongues of men and of angels: The Corinthians valued the spiritual gift of tongues the most (see also 12:10, 28; 14:1–25, 27). Some believed tongues were the language of angels. In Acts, Luke uses the same term for natural human languages (see Acts 2:4–13).

1 Corinthians 13:1–3

Spiritual gifts do not determine our worth to God or the church. Without love, spiritual gifts have no value.

1 Corinthians 13:1–13

Paul pauses his discussion of spiritual gifts (which he continues in chapter 14) to stress that love is more important than any spiritual gift (see 8:1–3). The most important goal for Christians is to become deeply and consistently loving individuals.

1 Corinthians 13:2

If I ... can fathom all mysteries and all knowledge: might refer to the gift of "special knowledge" (12:8).

1 Corinthians 13:3

- exult in the surrender of my body: Some manuscripts say sacrificed my body to be burned. A copyist could have easily changed the text by accident, as in Greek, the two readings differ by only one letter. It is unclear which reading is better. However, the manuscripts supporting the reading exult in instead of sacrificed are generally more reliable.
- I gain nothing: Even the most impressive sacrificial acts mean nothing if not motivated by love.

1 Corinthians 13:4–7

This description of Christian love highlights the readiness to sacrifice personal desires for the benefit of others (see also 8:1–10:33; Romans 5:6–8; 15:3; 2 Corinthians 8:9; Philippians 2:4–8).

1 Corinthians 13:5

it is not self-seeking: Love is not self-centered and does not focus only on its own interests (see Philippians 2:4–8).

1 Corinthians 13:8

Love will last forever, because God is love (compare 1 John 4:7–12, 16).

1 Corinthians 13:8–13

Love, unlike spiritual gifts, will endure forever.

1 Corinthians 13:9

None of the spiritual gifts provides complete understanding. Unlike love, their benefits are limited.

1 Corinthians 13:12

- The difference between now and the future is between this age and the coming age.
- Now, we see things imperfectly, like puzzling reflections in a mirror. In Paul's time, mirrors were usually made of polished bronze, so the view was unclear. Our perception in this life is limited, and our understanding is incomplete.
- Then, when the end comes and Christ establishes his eternal kingdom, we will see everything clearly. At that time, the spiritual gifts that provide knowledge will no longer be needed.

1 Corinthians 13:13

Faith, hope, and love are more important than spiritual gifts because they last forever (see also Romans 5:1–5; Galatians 5:5–6; Colossians 1:4–5; 1 Thessalonians 1:3; 5:8). Of the three, the greatest is love, because love is

the essential nature of God himself (see 1 John 4:7–12, 16–21). Therefore, love should define our relationship with him and others.

1 Corinthians 14:1

Among all the special abilities the Spirit provides (see study note on 1 Corinthians 12:1–14:40), Paul urges the Corinthians to seek the ability to prophesy because it benefits the church more (see 12:10) .

1 Corinthians 14:1–25

After highlighting the supreme importance of love (chapter 13), Paul discusses spiritual gifts again. He defines their value by how much they help others, which reflects love (chapter 13). With this in mind, Paul compares the overvalued gift of speaking in tongues with the more helpful gift of prophecy.

1 Corinthians 14:2–4

The issue with speaking in tongues is that listeners cannot easily understand the message. However, the gift of prophecy is clear and helpful. It is a message from God that strengthens, encourages, and comforts those who hear it.

1 Corinthians 14:4

The main purpose of spiritual gifts is to strengthen the whole church, not just to improve oneself (see 12:7; compare 8:1; 14:12).

1 Corinthians 14:7–12

A message must be clear to communicate well.

1 Corinthians 14:12

The Spirit gives special abilities to strengthen the entire church (see 12:7; 14:4; compare Ephesians 4:15–16).

1 Corinthians 14:13

Paul does not forbid speaking in tongues (see 14:39), but interpreting is crucial, especially in public worship (see 14:27–28).

1 Corinthians 14:14

Speaking in tongues involves the speaker's spirit, as the Holy Spirit speaks through them, but not their mind, since the message is not logically understandable.

1 Corinthians 14:15–17

- It is better to worship with both spirit and understandable words. Public worship should bless God and others. Speaking in tongues without interpretation glorifies God and helps the speaker (14:4), but it does not help others present.
- say "Amen" to your thanksgiving: Amen was the traditional response to a prayer.

1 Corinthians 14:18–19

Paul emphasized the personal benefit of speaking in tongues, but in a church meeting, it should benefit others, not just the speaker.

1 Corinthians 14:20

To understand these matters maturely, consider the purpose of spiritual gifts. Do not treat them as ends for personal enjoyment.

1 Corinthians 14:21–25

Paul used this quotation from Isaiah 28:11–12 to show that speaking in tongues is a sign for unbelievers, not believers. However, in 1 Corinthians 14:23–25, Paul argues that unbelievers are more likely to be convinced by prophecy than by speaking in tongues. He emphasizes that, in public worship, prophecy is more useful than speaking in tongues.

1 Corinthians 14:25

"God is truly among you!" Paul refers to Isaiah 45:14.

1 Corinthians 14:26

- has a psalm: Psalms can be sung alone or with others (compare Ephesians 5:19; Colossians 3:16).
- Everything done in public worship should strengthen the church (see 1 Corinthians 12:7; 14:4, 6, 12, 26; see also 8:1).

1 Corinthians 14:26–40

Paul provides clear instructions for using spiritual gifts in the church. He stresses the importance of expressing them in an orderly manner. In the early Christian community, church meetings were not led by professional pastors or priests. Instead, everyone shared what God had given them to strengthen the church.

1 Corinthians 14:27–28

Paul advises a church eager for the gift of tongues to limit its public use. He suggests no more than two or

three people should speak, one at a time, and only if someone can interpret the message.

1 Corinthians 14:29–32

Public prophecy should be shared in an orderly manner, guided by the Spirit, so everyone benefits. Others should evaluate what is said to determine if it is truly a message from God (1 Thessalonians 5:19–21). Those with a prophecy should take turns. Although prophecy is a divinely given message, the speaker still controls it.

1 Corinthians 14:34–35

- This part of the discussion on using spiritual gifts shows a view on women's roles similar to that of the Pastoral Letters (see 1 Timothy 2:11–15).
- Paul advises women to be quiet and respectful in church meetings. We should understand this instruction considering 1 Corinthians 11:5, which clearly implies that women can pray and prophesy in public.
- as the law says: This possibly refers to Genesis 3:16.

1 Corinthians 14:36–37

- As an apostle, Paul wanted the Corinthians to treat his words as commands from the Lord.
- What I am writing you: This likely refers to all his teachings, especially about spiritual gifts.

1 Corinthians 14:39–40

Paul summarizes his discussion on spiritual gifts in chapters 12 to 14.

1 Corinthians 15:1

The main message of the good news is the message of Christ's sacrificial death and resurrection (see 15:3–4; Romans 5:8–10; 6:5–11).

1 Corinthians 15:1–11

Paul summarizes the good news about Jesus he preached.

1 Corinthians 15:1–58

Some church members doubted a future resurrection of the dead. Paul reassures them and addresses their skeptical questions by discussing the nature of a resurrection body.

1 Corinthians 15:2

If you hold firmly to the word I preached to you: Those who stay strong in their faith will find salvation (see Matthew 10:22; 24:13; John 15:6; Galatians 5:4; Colossians 1:23; Hebrews 6:4–6; contrast with 1 Corinthians 1:8; Romans 8:38–39; Philippians 1:6; Hebrews 6:9).

1 Corinthians 15:3

The main message of the good news is that Christ died for our sins (see Romans 3:24–25; 5:8–10; Galatians 1:4; 1 Thessalonians 5:9–10).

1 Corinthians 15:4

according to the Scriptures: See Psalm 16:10; Hosea 6:2; Jonah 1:17; Matthew 12:40; Acts 2:24–32.

1 Corinthians 15:5

- He appeared to Cephas: See Luke 24:34.
- then to the Twelve: See Matthew 28:16–17; Mark 16:14; Luke 24:36; John 20:19.

1 Corinthians 15:6

More than 500 people saw him. We have no other record of this event. Most of these witnesses were still alive when this letter was written (around AD 53–56). People could verify Christ's resurrection by asking these living eyewitnesses.

1 Corinthians 15:7

Then He appeared to James: This James was almost certainly the brother of Jesus. He became a leader of the Jerusalem church after Jesus died (see Mark 6:3; John 7:1–5; Galatians 1:19; compare Acts 12:17; 15:13; 21:18).

1 Corinthians 15:8–9

- as to one of untimely birth: This phrase can refer to a miscarriage or stillbirth. Here it might describe the unusual way Paul converted, the negative view some opponents had of his role as an apostle, or his own feelings of unworthiness to be an apostle. The main focus is on God's extraordinary grace to Paul, who once persecuted Christ's followers (see Galatians 1:13; Philippians 3:6; compare Acts 8:3; 9:1–2).
- He appeared to me also: Paul met the risen Christ during his conversion (see 1 Corinthians 9:1; Acts 9:3–6; Galatians 1:15–16).

1 Corinthians 15:10

But by the grace of God: Paul understood God's special favor, or grace, towards him, which led to an extraordinary response. This response was also God working through Paul by his grace (see 2 Corinthians 4:7; Galatians 2:20; Colossians 1:27).

1 Corinthians 15:11

The important thing is the message, not the people delivering it (compare1:10–12).

1 Corinthians 15:12

Some believers in Corinth struggled to accept the Jewish idea of a bodily resurrection. They preferred the Greek idea of the soul's immortality (compare Acts 17:18, 32).

1 Corinthians 15:12–20

The resurrection of Jesus proves that a future resurrection is real.

1 Corinthians 15:12–34

Paul argues for a future resurrection.

1 Corinthians 15:14–18

If Christ did not rise from the dead, then the Christian faith is pointless. However, Jesus' resurrection proves that His sacrifice completely atoned for human sins (see 15:3). Without Christ's resurrection, people remain unforgiven and under God's judgment, still guilty of their sins (see Romans 3:19; Ephesians 2:1–3).

1 Corinthians 15:19

Without eternal life, faithful believers deserve pity more than anyone else because they face persecution and hardship. However, they find joy in looking forward to what comes after this life, just like Jesus (see Hebrews 12:2) and Paul (see 2 Corinthians 4:16–18; Philippians 1:21–23; 3:7–11).

1 Corinthians 15:20

In the Old Testament, people dedicated the first crop to God (see Exodus 23:19). Christ's resurrection is the first of many resurrections of God's people (see Colossians 1:18).

1 Corinthians 15:21–23

Adam's sin contrasts with Christ's resurrection (compare 15:45–49).

1 Corinthians 15:24

dominion, authority, and power: This phrase refers to spiritual forces that oppose Christ (compare Romans 8:38; Ephesians 1:21; Colossians 2:10, 15; 1 Peter 3:22).

1 Corinthians 15:24–28

Christ is the Lord of everything, including death. However, he is still under the authority of God, his Father.

1 Corinthians 15:25

- This paraphrase of Psalm 110:1 refers to Jesus (compare Hebrews 1:13).
- God has put everything under His feet: In the ancient Near East, artists showed victorious kings with their feet on the necks of their defeated enemies.

1 Corinthians 15:27

everything has been put under Him: See Psalm 8:6; compare Matthew 22:44.

1 Corinthians 15:29

Some first-century Christians practiced baptism by proxy for dead unbelievers they wanted to save. Paul does not endorse or condemn this practice; he uses it as evidence for belief in resurrection. Early Christian literature does not mention this practice elsewhere.

1 Corinthians 15:30–32

The apostles risked their lives because they believed in life after death. Without resurrection, their suffering would be meaningless.

1 Corinthians 15:32

If I fought wild beasts in Ephesus: Paul uses this phrase to describe his struggles with opponents in Ephesus (see 16:8; Acts 19:23–41; 2 Corinthians 1:8; 4:8–12; 11:23–28). Watching condemned prisoners fight wild beasts and get mauled to death was common entertainment in the Roman world.

1 Corinthians 15:33

"Bad company corrupts good character": This quote comes from the Greek poet Menander, who lived in the 300s BC. Paul uses it as a warning not to follow or listen to people who teach what is false.

1 Corinthians 15:34

some of you are ignorant of God: Paul strongly criticizes those who are proud of their knowledge but doubt the resurrection.

1 Corinthians 15:35–58

Paul talks about what resurrection bodies are like, possibly answering doubts. In the Greco-Roman world, people often believed the soul was immortal, but not that the body could rise again.

1 Corinthians 15:36

You fool!: Paul's strong response suggests skepticism. It might also imply that the answer cannot be known.

1 Corinthians 15:37–39

Just as a plant's shape does not look like its seed, the seed still determines the plant's growth. Similarly, the resurrection body will differ from the current body but will still be recognizable as the same person.

1 Corinthians 15:40–41

Everything God has made has its own glory. This means each thing has its own beauty and greatness. The resurrection body will also be different. It will not be like anything else.

1 Corinthians 15:42–44

Resurrection bodies will be very different from our mortal bodies, just as plants differ from the seeds they grow from.

1 Corinthians 15:45–46

Just as Christ's life-giving Spirit goes beyond natural life, the spiritual body will replace the physical body.

1 Corinthians 15:45–49

Adam and Christ created two different groups of people. One group is natural and earthly, bound by sin and death. The other group is spiritual and heavenly, cleansed and meant for life. Adam symbolizes the natural, physical body, while Christ represents the spiritual, resurrected body. See also 15:21–22; Romans 5:12–21.

1 Corinthians 15:47

Adam was made from the dust of the earth (Genesis 2:7), showing his earthly origin. This contrasts with Christ's heavenly origin.

1 Corinthians 15:48

- Earthly man: Like Adam, natural human beings face the curse of sin and death. All return to dust (see Genesis 3:19). They all die.
- as is the heavenly man, so also are those who are of heaven: Those who belong to Christ share in his eternal spiritual life.

1 Corinthians 15:49

Like Adam, the first man, we have physical bodies in this life. But one day, we will be like Christ, the heavenly man, and experience the kingdom of God with resurrection bodies (compare Romans 6:4–14).

1 Corinthians 15:50

Physical bodies cannot enter God's kingdom. Only a spiritual, resurrected body can fully experience the kingdom (compare John 4:24).

1 Corinthians 15:51

- The good news about Jesus reveals the once unknown secret of resurrection.
- We will not all sleep: Paul might have expected the future resurrection during his own lifetime (compare 15:52; 1 Thessalonians 4:15, 17).

1 Corinthians 15:52

Compare 1 Thessalonians 4:13–17

1 Corinthians 15:54

"Death has been swallowed up in victory": Resurrection defeats the ultimate enemy, death. The power of the Spirit helps believers overcome sin now (see Romans 8:2, 11).

1 Corinthians 15:55

- This quote from (Hosea 13:14 assures believers they need not fear death.
- Death is compared to the sting of a scorpion.

1 Corinthians 15:57

The death and resurrection of Christ end the control of sin and death (see Romans 6:14; 8:2; 10:4).

1 Corinthians 15:58

your labor in the Lord is not in vain: Those who serve him faithfully will receive eternal rewards (see 3:12–15).

1 Corinthians 16:1

Galatia was a Roman province in Asia Minor, modern-day Turkey (see Acts 16:6; 18:23).

1 Corinthians 16:1–4

Paul responds to the Corinthians' question about the donation for poor Christians in Jerusalem (Acts 24:17; Romans 15:25–27; Second Corinthians 8–9; Galatians 2:10).

1 Corinthians 16:2

Christians gathered on the first day of each week (see Acts 20:7) instead of the last day, as in the Old Testament (Exodus 20:8; 34:21; Isaiah 58:13–14). The first day was called the "Lord's Day," marking the day of the Lord's resurrection (Mark 16:9; Luke 24:13–15; John

20:19; Revelation 1:10). The amount of money to give was not specified. Paul later encouraged them to give as generously as possible (2 Corinthians 8:1–4; 9:6–13; compare Luke 12:33–34; 21:1–4; 1 Timothy 6:18–19).

1 Corinthians 16:4

Paul delivered the gift to Jerusalem (Romans 15:25–26).

1 Corinthians 16:5

- Paul traveled through Macedonia, a Roman province in northern Greece, during his second missionary journey (Acts 15:36–18:22).
- He planned to travel through Macedonia again (See Acts 19:21; 20:1–3).

1 Corinthians 16:6–7

or even spend the winter: Paul evidently did visit during the winter (compare Acts 20:2–3).

1 Corinthians 16:8

- Paul wrote this letter while he was in Ephesus, around AD 53 to 56 (Acts 19:1–20:1).
- Pentecost occurred in May or June.

1 Corinthians 16:10

- If Timothy comes: See 4:17. Timothy was Paul's spiritual child and co-worker (see 1 Timothy 1:2).
- see to it that he has nothing to fear: Timothy might have been shy or tentative (2 Timothy 1:6–8).

1 Corinthians 16:11–12

our brother Apollos: Refer to study note on 1 Corinthians 1:12.

1 Corinthians 16:17

Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus traveled from Corinth to visit Paul in Ephesus (see also 1:16; 16:15).

1 Corinthians 16:19

- Aquila and Priscilla (also called Prisca in Greek) had moved from Corinth to Ephesus, where Paul wrote this letter (compare Acts 18:1–3).
- the church that meets at their house: Aquila and Priscilla later continued this practice in Rome (see Romans 16:3–5).

1 Corinthians 16:19–24

Like in his other letters, Paul greets his friends and offers a blessing.

1 Corinthians 16:20

Greet one another with a holy kiss: People often greeted each other with a kiss on the cheek.

1 Corinthians 16:21

Paul ends the letter by writing a few words in his own handwriting. In those times, it was common for someone else to write down the letter as a secretary. Paul did this in this letter and in others (see Romans 16:22; Galatians 6:11; Colossians 4:18; 2 Thessalonians 3:17).

1 Corinthians 16:22

- To be cursed means to be condemned by God (see also Romans 9:3; Galatians 1:8–9).
- Come, O Lord!: Early Christians sometimes used this phrase in prayers (see also Revelation 22:20).

1 Corinthians 16:23–24

- All of Paul's letters end with a blessing like this one.
- Paul mentions grace at both the start and end of this letter (see 1:3).